Google predicted the flu from searches.

> Then 3-week-old data beat it.

50 million searches screened. 45 kept.

45

search terms in the final flu model (Ginsberg et al., Nature 2009)

Days, not weeks.

CDC REPORTS

1–2 week lag

GOOGLE FLU TRENDS

about 1 day

H1N1 arrives off-season. The model misses it.

> Critics later call it partly a 'winter detector'.

Predicting more than double what the CDC saw.

GOOGLE ESTIMATE

about 10%

CDC PEAK

about 6%

Too high in 100 of 108 weeks.

100 / 108

weeks overestimated, Aug 2011 to Sept 2013 (Lazer et al.)

Search itself kept changing: 86 changes in two months of 2012.

The tracker's rise and quiet exit.

- **2008** Launch
- **2013** 2x too high
- **2014** Science paper
- **2015** Shut down

Check any AI forecast with 3 questions.

1. Compared against what reality?
2. Checked how recently?
3. What changed upstream?